

Examining a Posthuman Understanding of Performative Being

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Introduction

Trying to make sense of the world visually is becoming more intricate, as images grow increasingly layered with personal and societal nuances. This evolution means that imagery has become a persistent part of our surroundings, blurring the lines between physical presence and imaginative realms. For me, imagery functions as a means to exist beyond the immediate, material world. Imagination, or the act of “weaving stories,” allows us to generate images that might be limited in their initial scope—produced privately, for a single audience—but still hold power to communicate to others. This imaginative process has the capacity to manifest “visuality” in ways that transcend the physical, forming new images and ideas that resonate beyond their origin.

Creating imagery in this way taps into cerebral power—the brain’s ability to piece together disparate and sometimes incoherent elements into a cohesive representation. It’s a form of visual production that intertwines with values, questioning perception and the ways we frame or categorize visual creations. This also raises questions about the agency of the mind: does our imagination need material grounding to create meaning, or does it possess a freedom that allows it to exist and generate images independently? This process of producing imagery often challenges the material world’s boundaries, showing that visual creation doesn’t require a physical medium to exist meaningfully.

With the advent of tools and technology for physical visual production, our imagination’s process has been influenced, guided, or at times constrained. These tools—whether they enhance, reshape, or entirely replace the role of imagination—coexist alongside human creativity in complex ways. The emergence of digital tools further complicates this relationship. Is the digital space an entirely new landscape where the imagination can accomplish what was once impossible, or does it provide an alternative form of presence that parallels, or even overtakes, the physical? Perhaps it’s a symbiosis—a shared space where imagination and digital presence allow for a transcendence of physical limitations. These interactions force us to reexamine the boundaries between physical and digital realities and challenge our understanding of what is “real.”

This interplay between human imagination and digital assistance also suggests a “posthuman” perspective, wherein digital interactions influence our social selves. In such a landscape, does

the posthuman merely participate in the social as an extension of our humanity, or does it stand as an independent presence with its own agency? Through this document, I aim to explore these intersections, examining both the conceptual and practical implications of growing up within visual and digital realms. By delving into these questions, I analyze and reflect on visual and digital productions, seeking to understand how these processes shape and reshape my approach to creating meaning in the visual world.

Reading Notes

Century of the Self: Happiness Machines

Introduction

Edward Bernays, often called the "father of public relations," was a pivotal figure in the development of modern advertising and propaganda techniques. Bernays used psychological principles, particularly those of his uncle, Sigmund Freud, to manipulate public opinion and turn individuals into passive consumers. In the 2002 documentary *The Century of the Self*, Adam Curtis explores how Bernays' strategies influenced consumer culture and public relations, demonstrating how individuals, once seen as autonomous, were transformed into commodities within the capitalist machine. By connecting the growing power of media with unconscious desires, Bernays set the stage for mass manipulation through visual and emotional triggers.

Reflections

What stands out about Bernays' work is his belief that individuals were easily malleable, not as complex, autonomous beings, but as part of a large, controllable mass. In *The Century of the Self*, Curtis argues that Bernays, like many of his contemporaries, viewed the public through a lens of manipulation rather than empathy. People were not seen as unique, self-determined individuals, but as a homogenous collective whose desires could be manufactured. Through advertising and media, Bernays created the illusion of individuality, but in reality, people's choices were shaped by external forces designed to fuel consumption.

Bernays took Freud's psychoanalytic theories, which focused on unconscious desires and the irrational aspects of human behavior, and applied them to marketing. This allowed him to view the public not as individuals but as a herd of emotionally-driven beings. His methods stripped people of their agency, replacing independent thought with desires that were molded by corporate and government interests. This process of dehumanization, where people are reduced to mindless consumers, reflects the darker side of mass media. The documentary highlights how Bernays' ideas directly contributed to a consumerist society where people unknowingly played a role in their own subjugation.

Bernays' genius lay in his ability to connect the visual and mental realms. He understood the power of imagery to influence emotions and desires, and he used this to craft a visual language that resonated with people on a subconscious level. Through advertisements and media campaigns, Bernays introduced the idea of associating products with specific emotions, symbols, and identities, giving rise to the modern marketing strategies we know today. He created an illusion of identity through consumption, allowing corporations to position their products as the means by which individuals could define themselves.

In the documentary, this visual manipulation is shown to be a crucial tool for controlling public behavior. Bernays' work formed the blueprint for a system where media, imagery, and consumer goods became inextricably linked to identity formation. This visual manipulation made it possible for corporations to design a narrative that people could buy into, quite literally. What was once seen as a personal or individual choice became something heavily influenced by outside forces, where media-driven identities replaced self-determined individuality.

Conclusion

The story of Bernays in *The Century of the Self* serves as a stark reminder of how vulnerable individuals are to mass manipulation. The rise of consumer culture, rooted in Bernays' methods, has created a world where identity is not something individuals construct for themselves but something they are sold through advertisements and media. Bernays and his contemporaries paved the way for a society where choices are not truly free but are shaped by powerful institutions that understand the psychology of mass behavior. His work demonstrates the dangers of allowing corporate interests to define public desires, with lasting consequences for personal autonomy and identity.

As we continue to live in a world dominated by advertising and media manipulation, Bernays' legacy remains ever-relevant. The documentary highlights the delicate balance between individual autonomy and the power of external forces shaping public opinion. While many of Bernays' techniques have become ingrained in modern marketing and politics, *The Century of the Self* also offers a warning: the more we allow our desires to be influenced by others, the more we risk losing our true agency and identity to the machinery of consumerism.

Sullivan, A. 'Karl Marx: Fashion and Capitalism' in Thinking through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists

Introduction

In Andrew Sullivan's "Karl Marx: Fashion and Capitalism" (2016), featured in *Thinking Through Fashion: A Guide to Key Theorists*, the author explores the complex relationship between fashion and capitalism through the lens of Karl Marx's economic theories. Sullivan critiques how capitalism commodifies both labor and the goods produced, with fashion serving as a crucial element in this process. Marx's theories on exploitation, class struggle, and the alienation of labor are woven into the fashion industry's dynamics, where trends are not only a means of self-expression but also a tool for capitalist profit, transforming both workers and consumers into cogs in the machine of production.

Reflections

One of the most thought-provoking aspects of Sullivan's essay is how Marx's theories are applied to fashion, revealing the industry's deep ties to capitalism's exploitative structures. The idea that workers, who produce goods such as clothing, are simultaneously transformed into consumers of those same goods creates a cycle that benefits capitalists at every turn. Fashion, in this sense, is more than a cultural phenomenon—it's a vital component of capitalism's ability to perpetuate itself by turning workers into consumers and commodifying even their labor. This resonates strongly in today's fast-fashion world, where the desire to remain trendy is inextricably linked to continuous production and the relentless exploitation of low-wage labor.

Marx's experience with pawning his overcoat is a striking example of fashion's role in determining social status. Fashion isn't just about aesthetics—it serves as a marker of class, access, and power. Marx's own financial struggles demonstrate how clothing and appearance are tied to one's position in society, something that is still incredibly relevant in modern capitalist economies, where clothing can symbolize wealth, success, and belonging. Fashion as a marker of status feeds into the capitalist system, perpetuating inequality by reinforcing who can participate in consuming status symbols and who cannot.

A key point that Sullivan emphasizes is how capitalist systems rely on the reserve army of labor—unpaid or underpaid workers from marginalized communities— to keep the cost of production low and profits high. This practice of seeking out cheap labor, often in developing nations, continues today in the garment industry. The exploitation of workers remains embedded in the fashion system, and it's not just about the labor involved in garment production; it's about the entire supply chain, from the raw materials to the consumer's experience in the marketplace. The idea that fashion itself is a commodity fetish, where consumers become enchanted by the superficial appeal of goods without acknowledging the labor and exploitation behind them, is an insight that helps us understand how deeply fashion is interwoven with capitalist ideology.

In reflecting on Marx's work, it's apparent that his critiques of labor exploitation continue to ring true. The fact that workers' labor is undervalued today—especially in industries like fashion—points to the ongoing relevance of Marxist thought. In many ways, the system has only become more efficient at extracting value from labor, while also alienating workers from the fruits of their own labor. Fashion companies push for faster, cheaper production cycles, often at the expense of worker safety and fair wages. The industry's rapid pace and emphasis on trends further entrench the capitalist need for ever-increasing consumption, making sustainable production difficult and innovation in labor conditions almost nonexistent.

I find the ongoing exploitation of labor in the fashion industry particularly alarming. Despite growing awareness of these issues, many consumers remain unaware of the human cost embedded in their clothes. This "reserve army" of workers—often women, children, and immigrants—continues to fuel the massive profits of fashion corporations. It's frustrating to realize that the more technology advances, the less control workers have over their labor. Marx's predictions about the mechanization of production and its effects on workers still hold true: technology often ends up serving to further exploit rather than alleviate the burden on labor.

Furthermore, the rise of handcrafting and small-scale production in textiles, in an attempt to reclaim labor power, ironically did not alleviate the pressure on workers. Instead, it created new forms of exploitation, as demand for "authentic" handmade goods often comes at the cost of low-wage labor in developing countries. This paradox only deepens the divide between those who benefit from the fashion industry and those who suffer from it.

The way fashion has become a symbol of status—where the rich and powerful continue to thrive while the workers remain unseen—is deeply unsettling. The politics of gender and labor in fashion are also significant, as women and marginalized groups are still at the forefront of low-wage labor while men (and large corporations) reap the benefits. This dynamic suggests that while the global labor market continues to shift, the underlying issues of power, class, and exploitation persist—often hidden behind the glittering façade of fashion.

Conclusion

Sullivan's analysis of Marx's ideas provides a crucial lens for understanding the intersection between fashion and capitalism. Fashion, as a rapidly changing commodity, serves as a tool of differentiation and social stratification, while simultaneously exploiting the labor force that sustains it. Marx's ideas about labor, value, and class struggle are more relevant than ever in examining the global fashion industry, where profits are made by keeping workers in precarious positions and consumers in a cycle of perpetual consumption. The capitalist system has found ways to perpetuate itself by dehumanizing workers, stripping away their labor's true value, and manipulating consumers through images of luxury and status. By revisiting Marx's work, we are reminded of the urgent need to confront these inequalities and rethink the way our labor is valued in the modern economy.

Gillian Rose: Visual Methodologies

Introduction

Gillian Rose is a renowned scholar in the field of visual culture and visual methodologies. Her influential book *Visual Methodologies: An Introduction to Researching with Visual Materials* (2001) provides a comprehensive framework for understanding and analyzing visual materials in research.

Reflections

The passage begins with a quote from Westerbeck and Meyerowitz (1994), which explores the intense and instinctive nature of street photography. The authors describe the act of photographing on the street as being akin to immersing oneself in the unpredictable and powerful flow of the sea, where the photographer constantly navigates new waves of human interactions, chance moments, and shifting environments. This metaphor reflects the challenging and exhilarating nature of street photography, demanding a tough, gut-driven approach to capture raw, fleeting moments that are often difficult to explain but deeply impactful.

Westerbeck and Meyerowitz's work is foundational to street photography discourse, highlighting the idea of "toughness" as central to capturing uncompromising, authentic images. This sense of toughness is often linked to masculinity, with the photographers' resilience on the street equated to a certain rugged, unyielding persona, which, in traditional street photography narratives, is associated with men. This gendered view of toughness underscores how the discipline has been shaped by male photographers, even as it reflects broader debates about power dynamics and the gaze in visual culture.

The notion of toughness in street photography, as described in the opening quote, resonates with the broader themes of masculinity and patriarchal perspectives. Toughness is not just a description of the physical demands of street photography but also relates to the emotional and intellectual detachment that is often required to capture "raw" moments. This detachment positions the photographer as an objective observer, often placing the subject of the photograph in a passive, objectified role. Donna Haraway's (1991) critique of the patriarchal "gaze" is

relevant here, as it points out the power imbalance between the viewer (often male) and the subject (usually passive), which is reflected in the production and consumption of images.

In this context, street photography can be seen as a way of maintaining distance and control, where the photographer's role is to observe and capture moments from a position of superiority, knowing more than the subjects in the frame. This detachment, while often described as "objective," erases the photographer's individuality and specificity, which Haraway argues is a characteristic of patriarchal modes of seeing.

Despite this, the passage also references the role of the "gut" and "instinct" in creating images, which introduces a contradiction. These elements are traditionally linked with femininity, suggesting that the type of masculinity required in street photography is a complex, nuanced form—one that incorporates both emotional depth and an outward toughness. This tension between toughness and instinct reflects the layered complexities of how gendered identities influence the practice and reception of street photography.

Furthering the discussion of gender and photography, the passage introduces auteur theory, which typically emphasizes the creator's vision as the primary force behind an image. In the case of street photography, this theory is critiqued as limiting, as it overlooks the broader context in which images are consumed. As Roland Barthes (1977) argues, the "death of the author" suggests that the meaning of an image is not solely determined by the creator's intent, but is instead renegotiated by the audience. This shift in focus allows for a more complex understanding of how images are received and interpreted, opening space for varied and personal responses that are shaped by the viewer's social context and experiences.

The concept of compositionality is also explored, with Griselda Pollock (1988) noting how the formal arrangement of an image can reinforce societal power dynamics. Pollock's analysis of Robert Doisneau's famous photograph, *The Kiss*, critiques the way the man's gaze and the woman's passive positioning reinforce traditional gender roles, with the viewer complicit in the masculine gaze. This analysis points to how the formal qualities of the image—its composition, framing, and focal points—serve to perpetuate gendered hierarchies, illustrating how photographic composition is a site of power.

Finally, the concept of audience, as proposed by John Fiske (1994), introduces the idea that meaning is not static but instead is actively renegotiated by the audience. Fiske suggests that the

way we interpret images is shaped by three modalities: the formal arrangement of the image, the technological context in which the image is viewed, and the social practices associated with the viewing context. These modalities influence how we engage with an image, whether we are viewing it in a museum, on a postcard, or as part of a commercial advertisement. The interpretation of Doisneau's work, for example, may shift depending on whether it is viewed as high art or in a more casual context, and how historical and social developments affect how the audience perceives gender roles and power dynamics.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the text emphasizes the complexity of visual culture and the multiple factors that influence how we produce, view, and interpret images. It highlights how gender, power, and social context shape the meaning of photographs, suggesting that images are never neutral but are always imbued with social, political, and cultural implications. The passage also challenges us to reconsider traditional analytical frameworks—such as auteur theory and compositional analysis—and to incorporate a broader understanding of the audience's role in shaping meaning. By examining the production, formal qualities, and reception of images, we can gain a more nuanced understanding of how visual culture functions and how it reflects and reinforces societal values. Ultimately, this approach invites a more critical and reflective engagement with photography, encouraging us to question not only what we see, but also how and why we see it.

Rosi Braidotti's Posthuman Knowledge

Introduction

Rosi Braidotti is a leading philosopher in posthumanism and feminist theory. In *Posthuman Knowledge* (2019), Braidotti offers a profound critique of humanism and anthropocentrism, providing a framework for rethinking humanity's position in a rapidly evolving, technology-driven world. While I was already familiar with some of the central ideas of posthumanism, Braidotti's work challenged and deepened my understanding. Her analysis of the interconnectedness between human, non-human, and technological realms struck a personal chord, reinforcing my belief that to truly address the dangers and potential of the posthuman, we must engage with it, not just theorize about it. To understand its power and its risks, we must work within its channels, exploring its implications and engaging with its realities.

Reflections

Braidotti's central argument—that humanity has been defined by negation—resonates with me deeply. For centuries, humanity has been conceptualized by what it is not—what it's not an animal, not a machine, not inert matter. This view, grounded in negation, upholds rigid hierarchies, dividing human from non-human, often with colonial, racial, and gendered exclusions. Braidotti's call to renegotiate these boundaries aligns with my own thoughts about cognitive capitalism. In my view, cognitive capitalism—characterized by the commodification of knowledge and information—is inextricably tied to the rise of technology. As Braidotti notes, technological advances rely heavily on the exploitation of non-human entities, from animals performing labor to non-human systems (like AI) that help create new technologies. For me, this intersection of technology and capitalism is a crucial lens for understanding the contemporary world.

If we are to challenge cognitive capitalism effectively, we must understand how it developed alongside technological advances. But technology, for all its role in reinforcing capitalist exploitation, also presents an opportunity for resistance. Braidotti's work sheds light on the duality of technology in this context—it can be both a tool of oppression and a potential agent for change. This paradox is something I've been reflecting on for a while, especially in how

hacking practices can be reconceptualized in the modern world. Braidotti's exploration of posthumanism gives me fresh insights into how we can rethink hacking—not just as a subversive activity, but as a form of posthuman cooperation, a way of challenging systems of control through technology. This framing feels like a direct response to the dominant models of cognitive capitalism.

Moreover, Braidotti's critique of anthropocentrism speaks to the larger ecological crisis we face today, and I feel it aligns with my own growing awareness of the importance of non-human agency. She introduces the idea of "multinaturalism" through Viveiros de Castro's Amerindian perspectivism, suggesting that different species experience the world differently. This is a key shift from the Eurocentric view that places humans at the center of the cosmos, a shift that I believe is crucial for understanding how to navigate our increasingly interconnected world. If we are to grapple with the posthuman condition, we need to rethink the human, not as an isolated species, but as part of a greater, interconnected web of life.

What truly stuck with me, however, was how Braidotti ties this larger philosophical shift to the lived realities of exhaustion, fatigue, and burnout, all symptoms of our modern capitalist society. The relentless pace of technological development, coupled with an ever-growing demand for productivity, has led to widespread fatigue—something that is all too familiar in today's fast-moving, tech-driven world. This fatigue, Braidotti argues, is not merely a personal crisis but a political symptom, one that signals the fractures in our current systems. To me, this aligns directly with the ways in which cognitive capitalism—and the technology that drives it—has led to the exhaustion of both human and non-human entities. We need to understand this fatigue as more than just a counterproductive side effect; it's a threshold, a point of transformation, where we can begin to reconsider what it means to live and work in this new world.

The question of "who is 'we'" in posthuman discourse also caught my attention. In a world where certain humans have been excluded from the category of "human" based on race, gender, or other markers, Braidotti challenges us to think more carefully about the term "we" in the context of posthumanism. This is not just a philosophical concern but a practical one for how we approach technology and power. Hackers, in this sense, could be seen as part of a broader posthuman movement that interrogates not only technological systems but also the societal structures that define human identity. Braidotti's ideas about the fluidity of identity in the

posthuman condition help me to reconsider the role of hackers in our world—not just as rebels, but as actors within a complex, technologically-mediated ecosystem.

Conclusion

In conclusion, *Posthuman Knowledge* is a crucial text for anyone grappling with the intersection of technology, capitalism, and identity. It offers new ways of thinking about how we, as humans, relate to the world around us—not just to each other, but to the non-human forces that shape our existence. For me, it's a reminder that the work of engaging with the posthuman is not a passive one. We must actively participate in its channels, understanding its complexities and contradictions in order to move beyond the rigid hierarchies of the past. By doing so, we can begin to confront the dual forces of cognitive capitalism and technological power, and maybe even begin to reshape the systems that currently control us.

Tim Berners-Lee: Weaving the Web

Introduction

Tim Berners-Lee is a British computer scientist best known as the inventor of the World Wide Web. He proposed the Web in 1989 while working at CERN, and later developed the first web browser and web server. His work has revolutionized the way information is accessed and shared globally. Berners-Lee's vision was not only to create a tool for communication but also to foster openness and collaboration across different spheres of society.

The essay *The World Wide Web: A New Communication Platform* (written with Fischetti in 1999) explores the transformative potential of the Web as a medium for creating decentralized, interconnected communities. In this text, Berners-Lee argues that the Web's design allows for the formation of both large-scale global networks and smaller, localized connections, avoiding extremes of isolation or homogeneity. He envisions the Web as a platform for collaboration and mutual respect, offering opportunities to reshape societal structures and systems of governance. Despite its utopian tone, the text raises key questions about the balance between freedom, control, and the emergent properties of a digital ecosystem.

Reflections and Critiques

While the text presents an inspiring vision of the Web as a delicate ecosystem, I find several of Berners-Lee's assertions problematic, particularly due to their lack of empirical support. His claim that "even in utopian communes, it doesn't work" (p. 200) is not substantiated by any psychological or historical evidence. Without context or specific examples, such sweeping statements seem more like opinion than grounded analysis.

Additionally, Berners-Lee's reference to the "geographical stability" provided by traditional geography is oversimplified. Geography has indeed structured our military and cultural systems, but the Web challenges these boundaries. The flattening of social hierarchies and geographic limitations through digital connection is transformative, providing opportunities for new forms of belonging that were previously impossible.

I also feel that Berners-Lee underestimates the challenges of scaling intuition in the digital age. He suggests that “accessing fast information on the internet is only useful according to the limit of our mental absorption,” but this doesn’t account for the overwhelming speed and volume of information that can lead to mental fatigue, rendering the “quick” access less effective. This connects to my concern about how the Web’s promise of decentralized intelligence might not always benefit the user; instead, it often overwhelms them, complicating decision-making rather than simplifying it.

Moreover, his treatment of emergent properties raises important questions. While it’s true that systems can display behaviors beyond the sum of their parts, I question whether these properties can ever be fully controlled by humans. The idea that the Web might develop its own agenda seems plausible, yet we must acknowledge that such development won’t necessarily align with societal interests or ethical frameworks. What emerges could be just as chaotic or even harmful as it is beneficial.

Cultural and Political Critiques

A critical issue I take with Berners-Lee’s idealism is his Eurocentric worldview, especially in his notions of the “right” thing or the “reward” system. These concepts are rooted in white, Western ideologies that fail to account for diverse global perspectives. By prioritizing these frameworks, he inadvertently supports a system that excludes non-Western ways of knowing and being. The assumption that people who spend most of their time at home struggle with balance and decision-making, for example, is both stereotypical and culturally biased. It ignores the varied experiences of isolation across different contexts and overlooks the deeper social, political, and economic structures that might contribute to such struggles.

Berners-Lee also seems to overlook the role of colonialism and white supremacy in shaping contemporary global structures. His call for collective responsibility in the digital space, while appealing, is overly reductive. It assumes a level playing field that ignores historical injustices. True equity and accountability in a decentralized, Web-based society can only occur if we first reckon with the power imbalances and legacies of domination that have shaped modern global relationships. Without addressing these disparities, the Web risks reinforcing them, rather than transcending them.

His reference to Unitarianism as a model for Web governance is also problematic. While Unitarianism offers an inclusive framework for spiritual practice, it still operates from a Western-centric lens that prioritizes certain theological ideas over others. The exclusion of Islam, for example, reveals a selective embrace of diversity. This selective inclusivity mirrors the Web's own contradictions: while it promises a platform for diverse voices, it often privileges certain ideologies and systems over others, especially those rooted in Western norms.

Conclusion

Despite the critiques above, I find myself continuously fascinated by Berners-Lee's concept of linking. The act of connecting disparate pieces of information, ideas, and communities is fundamental to the way digital ecosystems operate today. The Web, through its reliance on linking, serves as a digital blueprint for the decentralized, interconnected systems that form much of today's internet culture. I see this idea as a foundation for many of the open-source, collaborative, and networked cultures that continue to thrive in various corners of the digital world. Even as I critique some of the broader assumptions of his vision, Berners-Lee's emphasis on the power of linking remains a compelling framework for understanding how digital spaces can foster connection and creativity.

In essence, Berners-Lee's vision of the Web as a utopian tool for global connection is both compelling and flawed. While the idea of decentralized, balanced connections and emergent properties offers hope, the practical realities of scaling human intuition, navigating emergent behaviors, and addressing cultural and political biases complicate this ideal. His optimistic view of collective responsibility, while noble, glosses over the historical injustices that must be confronted before true equality can emerge in the digital age.

S. Lorusso: The User Condition: Computer Agency and Digital Behavior

Introduction

Silvio Lorusso is a researcher and writer whose work critically examines the intersection of technology, human agency, and digital behavior. In his 2021 article, *The User Condition*, Lorusso explores how digital technologies, especially in the context of the internet and social media, influence human actions, behaviors, and autonomy. Drawing from philosophical, technological, and socio-political thought, Lorusso critiques the reduction of human agency in an increasingly automated and user-manipulated digital environment.

Reflections and Analysis

Lorusso introduces a critical framework based on Hannah Arendt's differentiation between labor, work, and action. According to Lorusso, these three activities can be seen as forms of human behavior, with labor being the repetitive, automated task (e.g., browsing, feeding data into systems), work being the creative modulation of behavior (e.g., curating online identities), and action as the disruption of automated processes (e.g., breaking free from digital systems' repetitive patterns).

Reflecting on this, it's clear that Lorusso is critiquing how the internet, initially a space for action and deliberate choice, has increasingly become a platform for behavior. The shift to mobile, on-the-go usage—"a world that lost its definition"—has turned the digital experience into a continuous behavioral loop where human agency is diminished. This mirrors larger concerns about how users' interactions online are mediated and manipulated, often pushing them into repetitive behaviors rather than fostering authentic action.

Lorusso's discussion of agency is central to his argument. He suggests that agency involves making choices, while behavior is simply repetitive, automatic action without meaningful choice. The shift towards automated systems in digital spaces reduces the room for agency, leaving users with little ability to break out of pre-programmed behavior patterns. This is particularly evident on social media platforms, where algorithms and design choices nudge users toward passive consumption rather than active engagement.

The concept of "lock-in" aligns with Lorusso's critique of consumer capitalism, where the design of digital spaces limits user autonomy. The parallel to *The Century of the Self* (2002) is worth noting, as both Lorusso and the film's analysis highlight the role of manipulation in creating a compliant, consumer-driven user experience.

Lorusso draws from Norbert Wiener's work on cybernetics, particularly Wiener's fear that automation could lead to a world where humans become mere extensions of the machine. The idea of the "mechanically extended man" contrasts sharply with Wiener's vision of "Man-Computer Symbiosis," in which human and machine work together cooperatively. Lorusso's critique suggests that current automation trends reduce humans to passive participants in a system controlled by machines.

This critique raises important questions about how technology shapes human agency. The "mechanically extended man" creates a system of repetitive behaviors where the human is complicit, aiding the machine's operations without interrupting or altering the flow. Reflecting on this, I would argue that the potential for meaningful action within such automated systems is severely constrained, as the user's role is limited to performing labor that benefits the machine, not exercising creative agency.

Lorusso critiques modern computing as "impersonal"—simplified interfaces designed to reduce complexity for users at the cost of their ability to exercise control. This design philosophy is evident in the mobile-first paradigm, where user experience is standardized, and customization options are limited. The shift from open-ended tools (like personal computers that allowed more customization) to the more restricted environments of mobile apps represents a shift away from user agency.

This leads to "misconvenience," where tasks that once required user intervention are now automated, reducing the space for individual choice. Lorusso's argument about heteronomous versus autonomous convenience resonates with broader critiques of neoliberal capitalism, where user autonomy is sacrificed for the convenience of system designers. The user, in this case, becomes not a participant but a passive recipient of decisions made by the platform.

Lorusso uses the example of speedrunning in gaming as a metaphor for the ways in which digital technology has automated processes, reducing the time needed to complete tasks. While speedruns in games like *World of Warcraft* demonstrate the efficiency of automation, they also

highlight the loss of the rich, immersive experience that comes from taking time to explore a game world. Similarly, in social media and web browsing, the automation of tasks (such as endless scrolling) diminishes the depth of user engagement, privileging speed and efficiency over reflective action.

This concept of "misconvenience" further extends to broader digital behavior, such as in algorithmically-driven feeds (e.g., Twitter, Instagram). The simplification of user tasks in the name of convenience is, in fact, a subtle form of control, reducing the user's ability to choose their digital path and replacing it with automated decision-making.

Conclusion

Lorusso's *The User Condition* provides a compelling critique of how contemporary digital technologies—through automation, simplification, and algorithmic control—have diminished user agency. By drawing on philosophical and technological thought, Lorusso invites readers to reflect on the ways in which digital systems shape human behavior and action, often in ways that limit autonomy.

While Lorusso's analysis is insightful, there is room for expanding the discussion to include the global context of these issues, particularly in relation to how the design of digital platforms may disproportionately affect users in the Global South. Moreover, the discussion could be further enriched by considering the role of corporate power in shaping these systems, not just in terms of design but also in their ability to manipulate users on a massive scale.

In sum, Lorusso's essay is an important contribution to the conversation about technology, agency, and user autonomy. It challenges readers to think critically about the role of digital systems in shaping human behavior and to question how we can reclaim agency in an increasingly automated and controlled digital world.

Field Notes

Image as Digital Being

Introduction

In this field note, my objective is to track and reflect on the time and resources I allocate to visually stimulating content, with a particular focus on interactive and multiplayer gaming activities. In our contemporary digital age, there are growing claims that we are increasingly reliant on visual engagement to sustain attention and achieve a sense of occupation. Visual media, especially in the form of games and other immersive platforms, has become a central mode through which we pass time, absorb information, and even construct our identities.

This dependence on visual stimulation suggests that we are shifting towards a heightened attachment to optical engagement as a key means of navigating and processing the world around us. Whether through the compelling graphics of video games, the interactive dynamics of multiplayer environments, or the constant stream of visual content on social media, our lives are becoming increasingly governed by what we see and how we engage with it. This shift is not just about entertainment; it is about how we experience time, how we gather and interpret information, and how we perceive ourselves and others.

Interactive and multiplayer gaming, in particular, provides a prime example of this growing attachment to visual engagement. These platforms offer more than just a pastime—they create immersive worlds where players can interact with others, experience narratives, and solve challenges, all within visually captivating environments. The optical elements in these games are essential not only to their appeal but also to the sense of immersion they provide, drawing players in for extended periods of time. This continual interaction with visually stimulating content reinforces the idea that, in order to stay occupied or engaged, we need to be visually entertained or stimulated.

Furthermore, as we spend increasing amounts of time on these visually-driven activities, it raises questions about how this is influencing our broader relationship with time, identity, and knowledge consumption. The reliance on visual media to fill our attention could be shaping our

cognitive processes and social behaviors in ways that extend beyond the screen. Through this monitoring, I hope to gain insights into the extent of my own reliance on such content and reflect on its implications for how I navigate the digital and physical worlds.

Research Questions

- What percentage of my days goes to visual-culture oriented activities?
- What do I experience in these moments of engagement?
- What is a tangible result that I am left with in the end?

Methods

In the highly mediated society we inhabit, one of the most powerful tools at our disposal is the ability to capitalize on and collect matter—whether that matter is physical objects, digital data, or intangible resources like attention or trends. The systems we engage with, from social media platforms to market-driven economies, are designed to turn various forms of matter into capital, whether through monetization, accumulation, or strategic use. In essence, everything can be commodified, measured, and collected, allowing for the conversion of everyday interactions and exchanges into valuable assets.

By understanding how this tool operates, we gain the ability to "hack" or subvert it to our advantage. Hacking, in this context, refers not to malicious activity but rather to the creative repurposing or manipulation of these systems to collect information in ways that benefit us.

In the course of this field note, I aim to autoethnographically analyze the outcome of usage with a posthumanist eye, investigating the role of visual engagement as a technological product.

Conclusion

Through observance, approximately three quarters of my active time is spent on visually-interactive mediums. The main medium that occupies that largest portion is multiplayer online games.

During these prolonged hours, I am encouraged to feel excited and part of a collective activity. It doesn't express longevity in value, it seems to be a momentary enjoyment. It formulates itself however in the shape of a habit, and by default habits are often comforting to encounters.

There seems to be very little to no tangible result in the end. The product of this activity is volatile and immaterial, time-based value that is specific to the timeframe when it's practiced and expires as it ends.

In the next notes I aim at exploring specific elements of a singular example of the aforementioned MMO. I would like to map the specifics of this activity expressed in the visual composition and the tension build-up.

Posthuman Storytelling: Warcraft Series

Introduction: Posthuman Storytelling in Warcraft's Characters

Blizzard's *Warcraft* franchise, especially with *World of Warcraft*, exemplifies how RPGs can foster complex interactions with characters, where visual design and narrative depth enhance player engagement. Characters such as Thrall, Illidan, and Arthas embody posthuman traits that invite players to reflect on ethics, agency, and human-like connections in digital realms. This critical examination highlights how the posthuman attributes of these characters foster a sense of agency and presence in players.

Research Questions

- Is gaming just a game?
- Looking at Warcraft with a posthuman eye, how do these stories capture complexity?
- Is this layering relevant to the level of exposure presented?
- How do these manifestations navigate being interpreted physically or materially?

Character Visuals and Narrative Duality in Warcraft

Warcraft characters like Thrall and Arthas utilize a combination of narrative-driven design and visual symbolism, effectively creating ethical and aesthetic layers that transcend simple gameplay. Scholars note that the moral dilemmas faced by characters in RPGs promote a reflective experience, where players engage with concepts of justice, loyalty, and sacrifice, as explored by Jones (2008) in *Gaming and Culture*. This kind of ethical complexity is embedded in the visual storytelling of characters such as Thrall, whose shamanistic and communal values contrast with the power-hungry motivations of Arthas.

The dualistic portrayal of characters has been widely discussed, especially regarding *World of Warcraft*'s faction system, which encourages players to explore ethical choices across Alliance and Horde storylines (Corneliussen & Rettberg, 2008). These choices, represented visually through character design and narrative arcs, encourage players to confront philosophical dilemmas that align with posthuman concepts of identity and empathy.

Thrall's Community Focus and Illidan's Defiance

Thrall's character arc emphasizes communal values and cultural resilience, with researchers such as Bainbridge (2010) observing that Thrall's visual and narrative traits represent alternative leadership values, prioritizing empathy and shared heritage over dominance. This aligns with Donna Haraway's (1991) *Cyborg Manifesto*, which highlights posthumanism as a breaking of traditional, hierarchical structures in favor of connectedness and fluid identities.

In contrast, Illidan's rebellion is a study in moral ambiguity and autonomy, presenting choices that force players to question the ethics of self-sacrifice. Visual design choices—his glowing tattoos and demonic appearance—symbolize his outsider status and moral liminality, challenging players to engage with the tensions between freedom and sacrifice. This ambiguity echoes the insights of Deleuze and Guattari (1987) in *A Thousand Plateaus*, who argue that posthuman identity is characterized by flux and multiplicity.

Arthas: The Tragic Hero and Visual Descent

Arthas's transformation into the Lich King epitomizes a tragic journey of ambition and corruption. His visual progression—from noble paladin to dark ruler—represents the consequences of unchecked power. Studies by Heidbrink (2014) on video game narrative immersion explain how visual cues like armor design and color play a role in storytelling, conveying the depth of Arthas's fall and enhancing players' emotional connection to his narrative.

This tragic transformation draws players into a reflective process where they experience Arthas's ethical downfall, mirroring psychological and philosophical explorations of power's corruptive allure. Critics have noted the character's design as pivotal in conveying these themes, allowing for an immersive posthuman connection that challenges the boundaries between human morality and digital agency (Linderoth, 2011).

Conclusion

The *Warcraft* series demonstrates how character design and narrative depth in RPGs can encourage players to explore values of agency, sacrifice, and empathy. By blurring the line between human and digital identities, characters like Thrall, Illidan, and Arthas serve as

posthuman constructs that invite players to engage in ethical reflection, underscoring RPG gaming's potential for creating meaningful connections and reflective storytelling.

Games as Sites of Meaning

Introduction

The previously discussed model of RPG gaming illustrates a multi-choice, semi-open-end interaction that introduces complex structures of character engagement and player agency. Through this engagement, players imbue characters with layered meanings, transforming them into unique entities that diverge from their original design. This process is integral to the RPG experience; each character becomes a hybrid of pre-coded design and the player's unique engagement, a fusion that reflects both human choices and digital frameworks. Lorusso (2021) describes this phenomenon in *The User Condition*, explaining how players “infuse” digital entities with personality through repeated interaction, resulting in a new, hybrid human-digital amalgamation shaped by the time invested, decisions made, and individual “using behaviors” (Lorusso, 2021). This concept echoes posthuman themes, wherein digital tools and identities emerge as autonomous agents within a shared reality.

Secondly, players assign meaning to the time invested in these interactions. While time spent in the game world may lack tangible, physical outcomes, it yields digital production that is specific to the game's technical mechanisms. This production exists solely within the virtual sphere, where it attains intrinsic meaning through gameplay and interaction. Here, the game functions as a non-physical partner, enabling presence and agency in a domain beyond the physical. This insight highlights the juxtaposition between physical and digital experiences, where identity, value, and meaning emerge in realms traditionally devoid of material production (Sullivan, 2016). Analyzing this within a capitalist framework, Sullivan (2016) elaborates on how consumer culture instills physical objects with intangible value, shaping identity and moral constructs. When viewed through this lens, in-game accomplishments become comparable to commodities within consumerism, offering identity markers and value within a shared system that thrives on interaction rather than material gain. This dynamic interaction between digital and physical forms aligns with Marxist thought, emphasizing the economy of intangible value creation even in non-material contexts (Sullivan, 2016).

Research Questions

- How to investigate meanings being made in gaming?
- How to analyze the reasoning for these meanings and their sites of production using the previous readings?
- How to reflect and position my own experience as an embodied example?

Physicality and Neophysicality

Examining digital and physical domains in tandem offers profound insight into the changing definitions of presence and value. Traditional definitions of social contribution hinge on labor and tangible production, yet in digital environments, a different form of “non-presence” emerges as a valid and meaningful contribution. This shift challenges conventional views on physicality and labor, marking an era where digital contributions reshape social values. In my research, the concept of “digital waste”—time spent in games, often dismissed as unproductive—reveals alternative forms of production and agency. This “waste” holds value when digital space is acknowledged as a site for creating visuals, experiences, and interactions that blur the boundaries between the physical and digital (Rose, 2001; Braidotti, 2019).

Further investigating this posthuman shift, Shinkle’s (2012) insights on mirror neurons underscore the dynamic potential for RPG spaces to facilitate real-world influence. Through a mirror neuron framework, Shinkle (2012) explores how our digital interactions can foster real-life skills and empathetic engagement via embodied perception. Within an RPG, these “mirror neuron” responses could resonate endlessly, creating a domino effect where observed behaviors in the digital space influence subsequent digital entities, blurring the line between observation and participation. This process is enhanced by the digital nature of these entities, which possess specialized knowledge and abilities within their respective games, enabling users to engage in learning through imitation and practice in ways unique to digital interactivity.

Personal Reflections

Reflecting on my own gaming interactions, I observe that these digital experiences often evoke memories and achievements that hold similar emotional weight to my physical experiences. My RPG character, shaped by hours of engagement, embodies a sense of agency and achievement that mirrors human interaction despite existing solely in a virtual space. These

milestones—achievements when contextualized alongside others who invest similar time and digital presence—illustrate a distinctly “human reaction” within a “non-human interaction,” highlighting the blurred boundaries between digital and physical identities.

Methodology

In compiling this field research, I employed methodologies of observation and personal reflection, drawing on hours spent in-game and revisiting these experiences through the lens of artistic and posthuman research (Rose, 2001; Braidotti, 2019). Observation, as a key method in artistic research, allowed me to engage with my experiences in the game environment as a reflective practice. This approach helped me explore how prolonged engagement with digital forms of interaction informs both aesthetic and emotional experiences in virtual spaces. By actively observing digital practices, I uncovered deeper layers of meaning in digital interactions that extend into physical and emotional realities. Combining these observations with theoretical insights on posthumanism allowed me to reconsider how digital sites function as both reflective surfaces and sites of production, where visual and emotional meaning transcends the physical sphere.

Conclusion

This research into RPG gaming and digital interaction uncovers a rich landscape of hybrid entities, where users and digital frameworks collaborate to produce value and meaning beyond the physical. By engaging with these spaces, we partake in a complex interplay between agency, identity, and presence that challenges traditional understandings of production and social value. These findings suggest a broader cultural shift toward posthumanism, where digital and physical realms increasingly overlap, redefining presence, interaction, and the collective experience. Moving forward, this exploration invites a reconsideration of digital “waste” as fertile ground for meaning-making, reshaping how we perceive value in the posthuman age.

Bugs in Gaming: Classic World of Warcraft

Introduction

World of Warcraft was released in 2004 as an RPG model, building on the success of its multiplayer strategy predecessors, Warcraft I, II, and III. I vividly recall playing the original game on a dial-up modem, later upgraded to ADSL. As a middle-class gamer in Egypt, limited access to cutting-edge technology profoundly shaped my gaming experience. This often leads me to reflect on how technological advancements, designed within commodified frameworks, reward exploitative systems while punishing the communities they exploit. Commodities are valued according to the standards of those who profit from exploitation—a theme for another series of field notes.

In this field note, I reflect on the frictions present in the original version of the game, drawing on my personal experiences and situating them within broader socio-economic and technological contexts.

Research Questions

- How can I examine a model of gaming to investigate the nature of technological error and friction?
- How does friction relate to agency?
- How does this friction influence communication within the digital sphere?

Bug, Friction, and Accessibility in WoW (2004)

Inaccessibility is one of the earliest examples of physical-digital friction in modern technology. This friction catalyzed distinct socio-economic behaviors. Communities with access to technology experienced continuous accumulation of knowledge, while others lagged, advancing at slower rates and contending with more frequent and intense frictions. For those with limited access, “keeping up” often meant developing an oppositional relationship with technology accessibility—navigating frictions at an accelerated pace with limited resources.

I recall sharing a single account and computer with my three siblings. This dynamic, born from inaccessibility, shaped a unique way of maneuvering friction. For instance, we often watched

each other play—a communal activity that was enjoyable in its own right. As discussed in my previous field note on mirror neurons, this act of observation offered critical insights into navigating the digital world. Watching influenced my own behavior as a player, shaping decisions about whether to replicate existing strategies or experiment with unsolved frictions. Thus, friction itself became a tool for learning and adaptation, producing insights for confronting other “in-game frictions,” which I explore further below.

Bugs in the Original WoW

The original World of Warcraft was riddled with bugs, creating numerous in-game frustrations. Players frequently found themselves stuck in unintended scenarios, requiring either game support or, in extreme cases, character deletion. These bugs epitomized the friction between players and their environment, as well as between players themselves. Lorusso (2021) refers to this as the “user condition,” a concept describing the relationship shaped by the limitations of the digital medium as it replaces the physical one. The digital environment, in this case, acted as a medium of communication, and the frictions inherent in this environment had communicational implications. These bugs did not only affect how players interacted with the game world, but also how they navigated and made meaning within it—whether visually, experientially, or through the commodification of in-game knowledge.

The frictions in the 2004 digital world demanded adaptive strategies from players. For those with access to better resources—often white, middle-upper-class individuals—the bugs and glitches were mere inconveniences. However, for those with limited access, these frictions took on more profound meanings, particularly when considering broader disparities in technological access. The experience of these bugs was not uniform; players from different socio-economic contexts would reinterpret these issues in light of their own lived realities. While the bugs were unintended by the creators, their social redefinition by players transformed their significance, making the digital environment a space where users could impose new meanings onto the technological limitations they encountered.

One specific bug I recall involved a cliff where players, when stepping off the edge, would float in the air. Non-player enemies would lose interest and return to their original spawn points, while logging out would return the player to the nearest inn. Although initially a frustrating discovery, this glitch became a resource once understood. It was a unique friction, one that

defied the physical world's rules, and thus acquired a new layer of meaning within the digital space.

Communication and Connection Through Frictions

Reaching the maximum level in WoW typically required 15-30 days of playtime, or about 5-6 months. This prolonged journey compelled players to collaborate, bridging knowledge gaps and overcoming digital frictions. However, inaccessibility also meant navigating the unknown. Platforms like Thottbot (a precursor to modern guides) facilitated collective knowledge-building, embodying the true essence of RPGs. While this takes shape in the physical world, it is interesting to explore how it carries over into the digital world. Our willingness to replicate behaviors gained from physical presence into digital representations in virtual spaces highlights a broader process of adaptation. This process involves translating familiar, embodied experiences into virtual ones, as players attempt to re-establish patterns of behavior in new, often unfamiliar, digital environments. For example, just as we engage with each other physically, social interactions within MMORPGs like World of Warcraft draw upon similar dynamics of cooperation, competition, and social learning.

This replication of physical behaviors in the digital world is not limited to just social interactions but extends to how players solve in-game challenges. It can be seen as a strategy for coping with the unfamiliar frictions of virtual environments, such as navigating bugs or limited accessibility. These behaviors offer players a sense of control over the chaos of digital spaces, translating real-world strategies into new contexts to create familiarity and reduce friction. Ultimately, it is this intersection of the physical and digital that reshapes our interactions with both worlds, fostering new communities and social structures that transcend the limitations of each.

Knowledge about frictions became a valuable in-game commodity, fostering connections while also establishing hierarchies. Groups with more extensive knowledge of the game's mechanics and the ability to navigate or circumvent these frictions could both include or exclude others based on their proficiency. This dynamic mirrors Berners-Lee's (1999) observation on the

"linking" nature of the web, where friction not only facilitated collaboration but also reinforced exclusivity by determining who had access to knowledge and resources. Friction thus serves as both a tool for community-building and a mechanism of exclusion.

In World of Warcraft, this exclusivity manifested most clearly in the end-game content, where coordinated efforts from up to 40 players were required to complete certain activities. This elite standard is emblematic of broader socio-economic structures that reward those with greater resources—be they knowledge, time, or social capital—and limit access for those without. As such, the game's design reflects the real-world dynamics of access and exclusion, reinforcing existing power structures while simultaneously offering the potential for collective action and social mobility

Methodologies

This field note draws on personal experiences from WoW's early years, supplemented by insights from secondary sources examining the interplay of digital environments, friction, and social behaviors. The approach is critical and reflective, connecting individual experiences to broader systemic inequalities.

Conclusion

The original World of Warcraft demonstrates how digital frictions—bugs, inaccessibility, and the unknown—shape social behaviors and hierarchies within virtual worlds. These frictions, initially unintended by design, became tools for knowledge creation, community building, and navigating digital spaces. However, their meanings varied significantly based on access, context, and socio-economic background.

Evolution of Frictions and Meaning in World of Warcraft

Introduction

World of Warcraft (WoW), as discussed in the previous field note, has evolved significantly since its original release. Like many digital presences, it underwent processes of "refinement."

However, I approach this term with caution and skepticism, as I find it linguistically misleading. In this field note, I explore how these refinements affected the meanings players derive from the game and how they intersect with broader socio-digital behaviors.

Research Questions

How do changes in friction impact the social and exploratory aspects of gameplay?

What role does automation play in reshaping user identity and agency?

How do retrospective changes influence the cultural memory of a game?

Refined, Refurbished, and ... Automated?

Since its launch, WoW has expanded through ten iterations, gradually introducing changes aimed at reducing friction and creating seamless machine-user interactions. For example, mounts, initially a hard-earned milestone, became cheaper and easier to acquire. This removal of friction inflated the in-game economy, allowing products to become accessible at lower costs. Players no longer needed to undertake a series of quests or resource-gathering missions to obtain a mount.

On the surface, this change may seem trivial, but its implications are significant. Faster mounts diminished the need for player interaction and enhanced individual independence in a multiplayer environment, undermining WoW's communal ethos. The increased travel speed shifted focus away from exploration, fostering a goal-oriented engagement with the game world. Locations became waypoints to objectives rather than spaces of shared experience or visual-emotional connections. The reward structure shifted from a sense of presence and exploration to a clear, concrete objective.

Similarly, the automation of group formation marked a major shift in player dynamics. In WoW's early days, players needed to actively seek out others through in-game chat channels or digital forums. Mutual need fostered organic connections, often leading to long-lasting relationships. With expansions, an automated tool allowed players to input their role, class, and equipment specifications to be matched with a group. This system, akin to platforms like Grindr, facilitated efficiency but eliminated the need for communication or interaction. As Lorusso (2021) explains, this exemplifies "misconvenience," where efforts to streamline processes inadvertently erode the meaning and value derived from friction.

Made, Remade, REMAKE!

By 2010, WoW peaked with 10 million subscribers, only to witness a gradual decline in population. The seamless journey appealed to new players who had not experienced past frictions but alienated those for whom these frictions created meaning. This speaks to the dual-edged nature of refinement: while it increases accessibility, it also reduces opportunities for shared struggle and collective growth.

In 2019, Blizzard launched WoW Classic, catering to players nostalgic for the original game's frictions. Unlike earlier frictions, which were incidental, this move capitalized on friction as a commodity. Players returned to recapture the meaningful experiences tied to those challenges. However, the context had changed.

Knowledge, once created through collaboration and "linking" (Berners-Lee, 1999), was now readily available on countless platforms. This knowledge abundance introduced a new metric of community belonging: "viability." Players were assessed based on their performance potential rather than their ability to contribute meaningfully to a group dynamic. This shift mirrors the "neoliberal meaning of productivity," where value is determined by efficiency and output. Paradoxically, the wealth of information diluted individual identity. Players with similar knowledge and technical capabilities became interchangeable, reducing the uniqueness of their digital presence.

Revisiting Friction and Speedrunning

The automation and removal of friction had retroactive effects on WoW Classic. The gradual reduction of frictions in the main game altered players' expectations and behaviors. Lorusso's (2021) concept of speedrunning is particularly relevant here. Tasks that once required significant effort and time could now be completed in mere minutes. Players approached the game with an efficiency-oriented mindset, transforming it into a semi-automated performance where human users merely assisted pre-determined pathways.

Even in WoW Classic, this "refined" approach eroded the cultural memory of the original game. Players replicated the same automation processes, resulting in similar declines in engagement over time. Blizzard's recent announcement of a new Classic+ version underscores the cyclical nature of these refinements.

Conclusion

"Automation" fundamentally alters the meanings created within digital spaces. While it enhances accessibility and efficiency, it often sacrifices communal and explorative aspects central to player identity. As WoW evolves, it exemplifies the tension between creating a seamless experience and preserving the frictions that make such experiences meaningful.

Methodologies

This field note reflects on my experiences playing WoW, using Lorusso's concept of the "user condition" as a framework to analyze the pace of changes and their impact on player identity and agency.

Game Memory in Digital Ecosystems

Introduction

World of Warcraft (WoW) provides a unique lens through which to analyze the persistence of collective memory in digital environments. While previous field notes have examined the implications of automation and friction reduction, this note focuses on the socio-digital artifacts that shape and sustain cultural memory, even as the game evolves. By interrogating the interplay between past and present mechanics, this note explores how WoW creates and preserves its cultural legacy—and how players negotiate their place within it.

Research Questions

- How do design choices preserve or erase “game memory”?
- What is the relationship between nostalgia and participation in reshaped digital ecosystems?
- How do external knowledge systems (e.g., wikis, YouTube guides) influence the internal logic of game spaces?

Nostalgia as Mechanism

WoW’s iterative nature, punctuated by the introduction of WoW Classic and Classic+, underscores nostalgia as both a driving force and a design strategy. Blizzard’s reintroduction of “old frictions” seems to affirm the value of struggle and shared hardship as core to the original experience. However, the result is not a true recreation of the past but a curated reflection—akin to Benjamin’s concept of “aura,” where the original’s presence is altered through its reproduction (Benjamin, 1936). The past, when translated into the present, becomes a product of contemporary expectations.

For instance, players’ engagement with WoW Classic demonstrates an emotional yearning for what they perceive as authenticity, but this experience is shaped by modern tools and meta-knowledge. The ubiquity of online resources transforms previously opaque systems into predictable algorithms, reducing exploratory wonder. Nostalgia, in this context, functions as a double-edged sword: it enables emotional connection while diminishing the serendipity that once defined it.

Knowledge Systems and Cultural Mediation

One of the key shifts in WoW's ecosystem is the externalization of knowledge. Early players learned through embodied play, trial and error, and community forums. Now, most challenges are preemptively solved through easily accessible guides. This creates what Haraway (1988) might describe as a "split epistemology"—the bifurcation between embodied, lived experience and disembodied, hyper-mediated knowledge. Players no longer confront the game directly; they mediate their engagement through a lens of algorithmic optimization.

This externalization mirrors trends in broader socio-digital contexts, where the user's role is increasingly defined by their ability to consume and apply pre-existing knowledge rather than to generate or negotiate it. In WoW, the emphasis shifts from interaction within the game to mastery over its systems.

Friction as Artifact

In this context, friction operates as an artifact of memory rather than an active feature of gameplay. Players in WoW Classic replicate the original game's frictions, but their engagement is informed by modern efficiency tools and external knowledge. This creates a paradox: while friction is nostalgically celebrated, its practical function is often bypassed, reducing it to a symbolic gesture rather than an experiential reality.

This phenomenon parallels trends in broader cultural memory practices, where historical reenactments or digital archives offer selective reconstructions rather than authentic experiences. The friction that once required collective problem-solving now exists as a simulacrum, devoid of its original meaning but laden with new symbolic value.

Conclusion

This note would ultimately reflect on how WoW's evolving ecosystem serves as a microcosm for the digital age's approach to history, memory, and cultural legacy. By preserving fragments of its past within a modern framework, WoW demonstrates how digital spaces negotiate between authenticity and accessibility, constructing narratives that cater to both nostalgia and efficiency.

Conclusion

Content

The exploration of visual activities, especially through frameworks like Rose's *Visual Methodologies* (2001) and Braidotti's *Posthuman Knowledge* (2019), deepened my understanding of how visuals communicate meaning beyond their immediate representations. Rose's examination of the "sites" of an image—its production, the intended and actual audience, and the socio-political contexts it inhabits—provided a foundation for this inquiry. Her focus on the emotional resonance or "affectus" of visuals helped me move beyond superficial interpretations, urging me to look at how images engage the viewer on an emotional level and the broader implications of this engagement. Rose's approach allowed me to view images not just as static, isolated objects but as dynamic entities that interact with audiences, influencing perceptions and shaping emotional responses.

Incorporating Braidotti's posthuman perspective, which challenges the human-centered framework of visual analysis, further enriched this understanding. Braidotti proposes that non-human agency—whether digital software, algorithms, or technological interfaces—plays a crucial role in the production of visuals. This shifted my view of visuals from being solely a product of human creativity to a collaborative creation involving technological tools. The idea that technology itself participates as a co-creator in the meaning-making process resonated strongly with my understanding of digital media. I began to see images as collaborative outputs, where human intention and technological processes merge to create complex meanings and experiences that transcend traditional boundaries between human and machine.

One of the key insights gained through this process was the realization that visuals occupy multiple planes and exist in layers. They are not confined to their aesthetic function but move through various contexts, extending their influence across digital and

physical realms. Visuals, in this sense, become active agents, shaping and reshaping the way we interact with the world. This new perspective on visual media as something more than an aesthetic object—something that moves and interacts, shifting meaning across different contexts—became central to my analysis. This conceptual shift allowed me to view digital environments, like those in gaming, not just as spaces for passive consumption but as arenas of active engagement where visuals, narratives, and the participants are intertwined.

Through the lens of posthuman insights, I began to reframe the role of digital media—particularly in the context of online gaming—as a site where meaning is co-created by both human players and the technologies they engage with. In my reflection on personal gaming experiences, particularly with World of Warcraft (WoW), I found that these virtual spaces were not devoid of depth or significance, as commonly presumed. Instead, they embodied complex interactions between users, digital landscapes, and the frictions that arise within these spaces. The digital world of WoW became a testing ground for exploring concepts of agency, knowledge, and communication within posthuman contexts. The experiences of navigating frictions—whether technical bugs, in-game limitations, or socio-economic access—highlighted the adaptability of players and their ability to extract meaning and value from what were initially seen as disruptive forces.

Methodologies

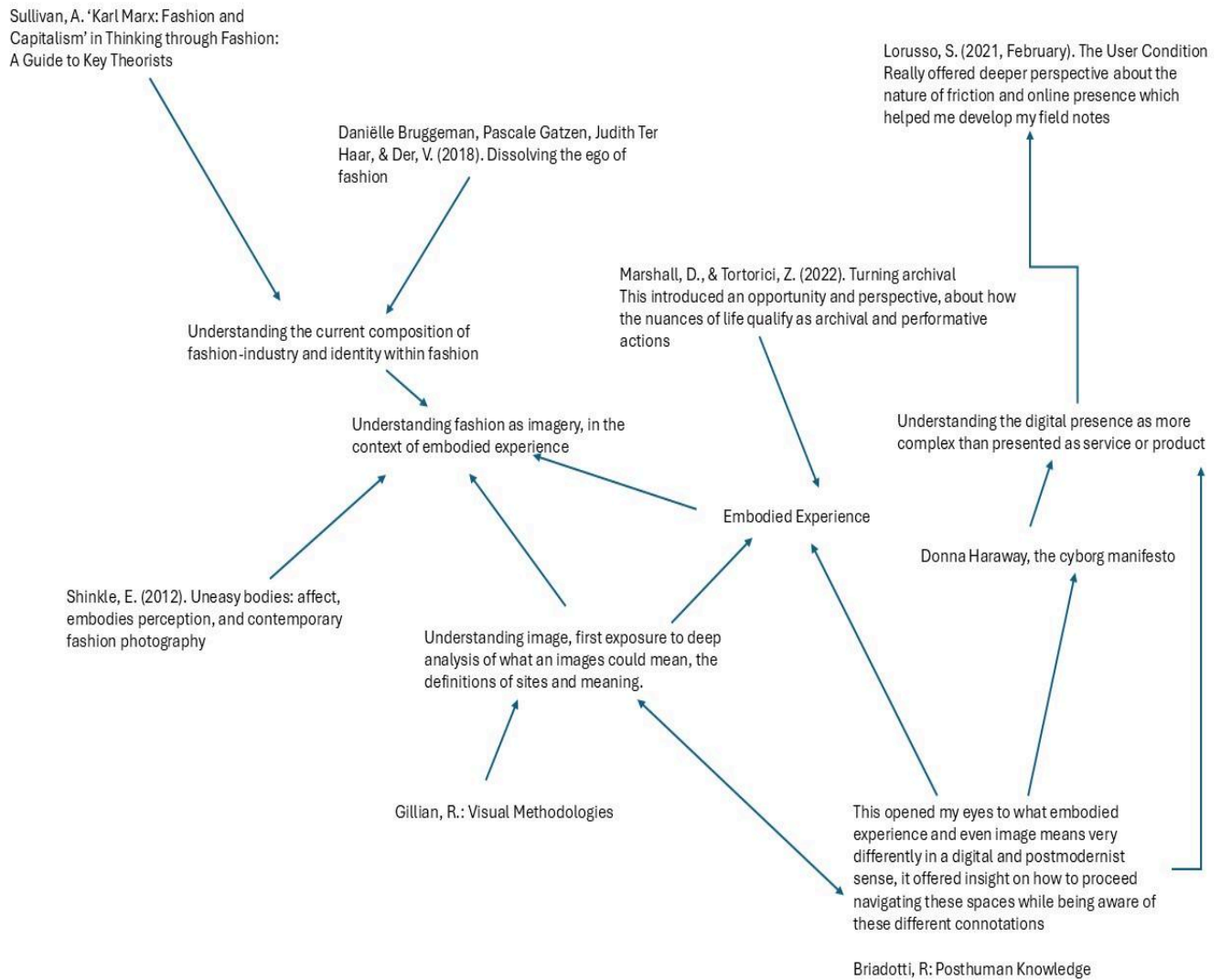
The methodologies employed in this analysis were primarily rooted in autoethnography, which enabled me to reflect critically on my personal experiences within gaming, while also connecting these insights to broader theoretical frameworks. As a long-time gamer, particularly within MMORPGs like World of Warcraft, I used this semester's exploration as an opportunity to reconsider and deepen my understanding of the gaming process, moving beyond the negative perceptions often attached to gaming as a trivial or shallow activity.

Autoethnography, in this case, allowed me to center my personal gaming practices as both subject and object of research, reflecting on how my interactions within digital spaces could reveal broader themes about technology, society, and identity. Drawing on the readings by Rose and Braidotti, I focused on how my gaming activities functioned within a complex matrix of cultural, technological, and emotional layers. In particular, I explored how my engagement with visual content in gaming was not just about enjoyment but involved deeper reflections on the nature of digital interactions, the role of technology in shaping meaning, and the posthuman dynamics at play in virtual worlds.

In addition to autoethnographic reflection, I also drew on the theoretical insights of scholars like S. Lorusso, whose work on the "user condition" informed my understanding of the relationship between humans and posthuman technologies. Lorusso's concept of "frictions" became a central tool for examining how the limitations of technology—whether technical glitches, inaccessibility, or the inherent challenges of digital environments—shape user experiences and influence how players make meaning within these spaces. This notion of friction helped me understand the complex interactions between users, technology, and the digital space they inhabit, highlighting how players adapt to and overcome obstacles in ways that reshape their relationship with the technology.

Through these methodologies, I was able to move beyond simplistic interpretations of gaming as a form of entertainment and instead engage with it as a site of intellectual, emotional, and socio-political meaning. The combination of autoethnographic reflection and theoretical inquiry allowed me to explore how my personal gaming experience could serve as a microcosm for broader questions about agency, communication, and the role of technology in shaping human behaviors and interactions. Ultimately, the methodologies employed helped me to see the gaming experience as a complex interplay of human and non-human forces, offering new insights into the nature of virtual spaces and the ways in which we engage with them.

Mapping



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